

Seamless, serendipitous, intimate

Ethnographic reflections on the qualities of machine companionship

Dr Andreas Schellewald

Dr Yingwen Wang

Dr Yiting Wang

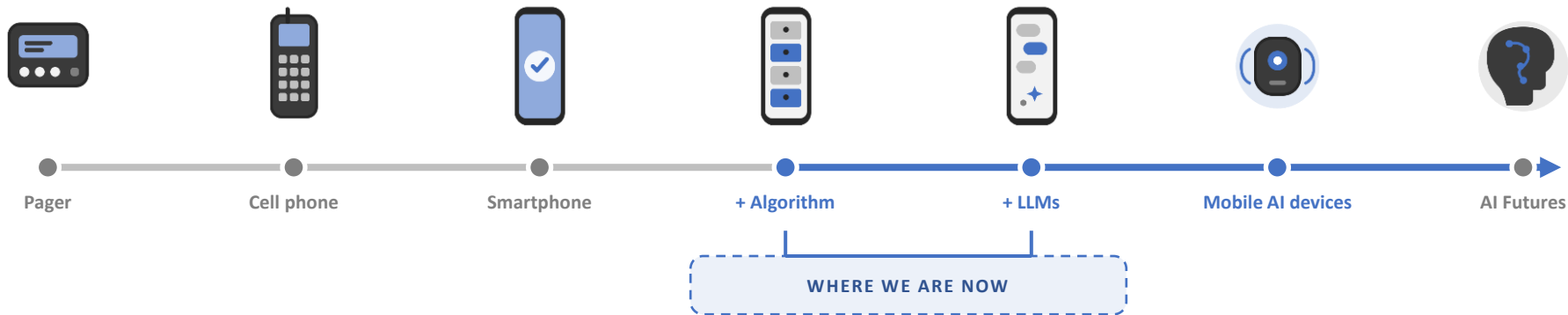


AI moving into 'the wild'

AI tools are becoming mundane. ~10% of adults use tools like ChatGPT, and 73% of chats are non-work related (Chatterji 2025) — a growing need to understand how “*Global AI*” lands in local, socio-cultural worlds (Ge et al. 2024, Lu et al. 2025, Natale et al. 2025, Siles 2023).

THE NEXT COMPANION

Mobile AI devices may replace the smartphone as our daily companion (Goggin 2025).



Reflections from 41 months in the field

Three ethnographic projects that studied how social media algorithms accompany people in their daily social lives

TikTok	YOUNG	Douyin	OLD	Instagram Reels	COMMUNITY
18 months · from 2020		9 months · from 2024		14 months · from 2023	
WHO		WHO		WHO	
30 UK young adults (late teens–early 20s), diverse backgrounds		23 older adults (60–80) in China, diverse socio-economic backgrounds		Cultural artefacts: 804 “send this” videos	
HOW		HOW		HOW	
Interviews, participant observation, media mappings, digital fieldwork		Interviews + in-person participant observation		Daily walkthroughs, digital fieldwork, artefact collection	

FROM THREE STUDIES TO ONE FRAMEWORK



Three key qualities of machine companionship

Identified as recurring themes across the studies and across the social and cultural contexts studied

	 Seamlessness	 Serendipity	 Social intimacy
 Role	Machine companions eases the conduct of daily life in a fragmented world.	Machine companions enable unexpected social connections and sense of affinity.	Machine companions re-shape logics of social valuation & significance.
 Change	New forms of mood management & emotional regulation.	New forms of context collapse & local social networking practices.	New dynamics of social inclusion & AI-mediated social recognition.
 Meaning	Machines help create “order out of chaos” and a sense of ontological security.	Machine companionships produce eudaimonic effects of uplift and reflection.	Machine companions produce a sense for social value, worth, significance of others.
 Challenge	Trust and dependency with the machine taking over the cultural work of “ordering”.	Contextual integrity and value ethics as machines observe + orchestrate networks.	Challenges of exclusion and cultural homogenization as machines shape value.

Possible discussion topics

What are your thoughts about linking algorithms and LLMs / Mobile AI historically in their companion roles?

AI tools are becoming mundane. ~10% of adults use tools like ChatGPT, and 73% of chats are non-work related (Chatterji 2025) — a growing need to understand how “Global AI” lands in local, socio-cultural worlds (Ge et al. 2024, Lu et al. 2025, Natale et al. 2025, Siles 2023).

THE NEXT COMPANION

Mobile AI devices may replace the smartphone as our daily companion (Goggin 2025).



What dimensions / qualities do you feel are missing in the framework?

	Seamlessness	Serendipity	Social intimacy
Role	Machine companions eases the conduct of daily life in a fragmented world.	Machine companions enable unexpected social connections and sense of affinity.	Machine companions re-shape logics of social valuation & significance.
Change	New forms of mood management & emotional regulation.	New forms of context collapse & local social networking practices.	New dynamics of social inclusion & AI-mediated social recognition.
Meaning	Machines help create “order out of chaos” and a sense of ontological security.	Machine companionships produce eudaimonic effects of uplift and reflection.	Machine companions produce a sense for social value, worth, significance of others.
Challenge	Trust and dependency with the machine taking over the cultural work of “ordering”.	Contextual integrity and value ethics as machines observe + orchestrate networks.	Challenges of exclusion and cultural homogenization as machines shape value.